

Flooding and Isolation of Alviso

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Abstract

Alviso is a small town located in North San Jose, near the southern shores of San Francisco Bay. Alviso was a growing port town that was regularly used with steamboats to transport goods and people between San Francisco and Alviso. Alviso had a storage and manufacturing business along with a large cannery business there. Later on, a railroad was integrated into the area making it the main hub for transportation and canning. Further down the line, Alviso became an agricultural location that housed farmers. However, as it was just growing, there were many negative outcomes that contributed to the downfall of the town over the next few years. From the past natural disasters, the geography of the area, engineering, and businesses to current funding, resources, health care, engineering, and general care for the town, Alviso has not evolved as much as the rest of the Bay Area. The main one is the topography of the land. This resulted in many lower-income communities, mostly people of color, to settle down in Alviso. Alviso has been on the back of the government's mind while the rest of the Bay Area flourishes and Alviso is left in the past.

Flooding and Isolation of Alviso

The Bay Area is the global technology center, so this would also mean everything in the area would be up to date and have access to resources. Unfortunately, this is not true. There are many towns that are not funded enough to access these resources. One of these places is Alviso. Alviso is a small town that most locals in the Bay Area do not know about. There are a few locals who know about this town because of being residents or having family there and people who walk the trail. The reason for Alviso being such a small unknown town is interesting because of its historic value in the growth of the Bay Area. The town is the connection between San Francisco and southern Bay Area. However, this did not last long, and the town became isolated from the rest of the area causing it to take a step back in time while the city around it continued to grow. There have been talks for many years about helping Alviso but there have been no such results or efforts occurring for the people in the community. This case study will encapsulate the growth and decline of Alviso, a town whose location made it the center for transportation, canning, and agriculture. All, while these economic achievements attracted working people of color, Alviso being located on floodplains and the low monetary value of the land, resulted in an economic and infrastructural decline. This study explores how these environmental and socioeconomic factors shaped Alviso.

Residents

Before Alviso was taken over by settlers, the Native American Tribe that lived there was the Muwekma Ohlone Tribe. They were located all throughout what is now the Bay Area, these were: San Francisco Country, San Mateo County, Santa Clara County, Alameda County, Contra Costa County, and parts of Napa County, Santa Cruz County, Solano County, and San Joaquin County (ThemeZaa, n.d.). Alviso was located in the Tamien tribal area. Spanish missionaries

took over the land that the Native Americans lived on and in 1777 founded Pueblo de San José de Guadalupe and Mission Santa Clara de Asís. In the 1800s the embarcadero of Mission Santa Clara turned into a community and trading area which became Alviso. In the 1830s, Mission Santa Clara split into agricultural properties which were given to citizens. In 1838, Juan Ignacio was granted a 6,353 acre area and settled in 1840. Over the next years as the community built up and grew so did the diversity of the community. There were Chinese, Japanese, Portuguese, and Mexicans who lived there for various reasons. In 1870, male Chinese residents became more prominent in Alviso because of the cannery company being moved down there and the company was all operated by the Chinese community. In the early 1900s, the Japanese community moved to Alviso because of the housing that was provided. Japanese males during this time were working on the railroad to San Francisco so Alviso became home to them. The Portuguese community joined Alviso because they worked at the canning company, railroad, and dairy farm which were in or near Alviso. In the 20th century, there was a change in Mexican residents because of the need for labor in the agricultural section (Jose, 2024).

There has been a decline in residents in Alviso. In 2000, there were 2,128 people and in 2010, there were 2,077 people. As of 2023, there are about 1,627 residents in Alviso (*95002 Zip Code (San Jose, California) Profile - Homes, Apartments, Schools, Population, Income, Averages, Housing, Demographics, Location, Statistics, Sex Offenders, Residents and Real Estate Info*, 2023). Since the town is underfunded and in vulnerable areas, it has housed mostly people of color and low income communities. The town consists of older residents or residents who have grown up there and want to continue their life there. There are mostly 58.7% Hispanic/Latino descent, 23.1% Asians, 14% White, 2.2% Two or more race, and 2% other (*95002 Zip Code (San Jose, California) Profile - Homes, Apartments, Schools, Population,*

Income, Averages, Housing, Demographics, Location, Statistics, Sex Offenders, Residents and Real Estate Info, 2023). Throughout the United States, it is common for residents who live near floodplains to be people of color for the most part. “For example, flood mitigation efforts have often prioritized wealthier and whiter communities, where property values are higher. For communities of color, like those in Baton Rouge, flooding-related infrastructure is crumbling” (Mendonca, 2024). However, there might be some cases where this is not true.

Income

In 2000, about 7% of the residents were living below the federal poverty line. About 23% of residents worked in manufacturing, 14% worked in construction, 12% worked in retail, and 11% worked in professional, scientific, management, administrative, and waste management services according to the Masters degree candidates of the Urban & Regional Planning Department. (2009).

Topography

Alviso is located in North San Jose and the southern part of the San Francisco Bay. Some other bodies of water near Alviso are Alviso Slough, Guadalupe River, and Coyote Creek. The land was attractive to people because of how much there was for a low value. Additionally, the location was perfect for quick transportation of goods, people, and other items.

Cannery

One of the main businesses in Alviso was the cannery. This was the third largest canning company in the United States of America. It was founded by Sai Yin Chew, a Chinese man, in 1890. At first, it was named the Precita Canning Company. Everyone who worked in the factory was of Chinese descent. At first, this canning company was located in San Francisco however because of the 1906 earthquake and fire caused alongside it, the cannery was reorganized in

Alviso and named the Bay Side Cannery. During this time, there was xenophobia and discrimination occurring against Chinese laborers. Chew built housing, paid, and hired Chinese labor for the cannery. The Bay Side Cannery consisted of seven buildings which were: the cold storage plant, main cannery, office, “China Camp”, site of apple drier, Tom Foon Chew Home, and the cabins. The main cannery was a rented building which was the Alviso Water Factory, the cold storage was the former Cribari Winery. Later the area around it was brought to build cabins, housing, and a warehouse (*Five Views: An Ethnic Historic Site Survey for California (Chinese Americans)*, 2025). The cannery included many canned products. They were canned as “spinach, asparagus, cherries, apricots, plums, peaches, pears, tomatoes, catsup, tomato sauce, hot sauce, tomato puree, fish sauce, and fruit cocktail” (research4fbf63128f, 2021). Tomas Foon Chew, Sai Yin Chew’s son, was involved in the Bay Side Cannery and created many new innovations. These innovations were better techniques for sanitation, creating ketchup to use the spoiled tomatoes, and canning green asparagus. This led the Bayside Cannery to become the third largest cannery in the United States and the Chew family to be the wealthiest Chinese American in the United States and America. Thomas Foon Chew had such a large impact on the community that he had 25,000 mourners during his funeral in 1931. After the passing of Chew, just five years later, in 1936, the cannery closed during the Great Depression also resulting in the slow decline of the cannery and town in the mid 20th century (Ricci, 2025).

Steamboat

Steamboats were a large part of Alviso since it was a port town. It was the connection between San Francisco and the South Bay. The Port of Alviso opened in 1840 at the front of Guadalupe River where it meets the San Francisco Bay. It was a major shipping port for all of Santa Clara for thirty years, from 1840 - 1870. The United States Congress also designated

Alviso as the port to receive foreign goods in 1862. The port was listed as a Historic Place in the National Register in 1973. This was one of the reasons that Alviso was greatly growing and popular during the time. The route from Alviso to San Francisco was called the Steamboat Slough. It took about 10 hours and was \$40 for a one way trip (*City of San Jose Blog | City of San José*, 2023). However, there was an unfortunate accident that frightened many people. On April 11, 1853, while the steamboat, named Jenny Lind, was traveling its regular route, a boiler of the boat exploded. This resulted in 31 passengers being killed. There was another steamboat, called The Alviso, which continued operating until the 1890s (research4fbf63128f, 2021). However, starting from 1864, there was a decline in the port being used after the railroad was completed (*Alviso Port and Steamboat Tragedy - FoundSF*, 2020).

Railroad

Alviso was a freight transportation area between San Francisco and Santa Clara for about thirty years, from 1840 - 1870. The railroad from San Francisco to San Jose was completed in 1864. This railroad ran through Alviso and in the 1880s they added a stop in Alviso on the way to San Francisco on the Newark line (research4fbf63128f, 2021). In 1871, the South Pacific Coast Railroad was the main train to go through Alviso. The railroad was less expensive compared to the steamboat (Masters degree candidates of the Urban & Regional Planning Department, 2009). The railroad however did not help in regaining the growth that Alviso once had. During this time, there was hydraulic mining being done in the Sierra foothills that caused silting to the lower San Francisco Bay (*Alviso Port and Steamboat Tragedy - FoundSF*, 2020).

Agriculture

Alviso had many successful businesses in the agricultural sector as well. This is because of the rich soil and low fog (Masters degree candidates of the Urban & Regional Planning

Department, 2009). In the beginning, there was also a boom in agriculture when wheat peaked at 300 barrels of flour a day in 1853. However, as the production grew in San Joaquin Valley, it slowed in Santa Clara Valley resulting in the closure of Alviso Mills in 1885 (research4fbf63128f, 2021). Late in the 1870s, there was a shift to fruits and orchards. The orchards had strawberries, apples, peaches, prunes, and currents. These orchards would go on for miles because of the soil quality related to the San Francisco Bay nearby. As a result, farmers would rely on flood water to irrigate orchards or the artesian wells they created (Masters degree candidates of the Urban & Regional Planning Department, 2009). Alviso had pear orchards as well since floods would occur but they would not damage the roots (Fuentes, 2024). In the 20th century, there was a demographic change to Mexican residents because of the need for labor in the agricultural sector. The open space near the salt marsh was developed to accommodate them and eventually turned into a neighborhood. This consisted of relocated houses from workers of the closed cannery and migrant labor camps from the previous residents. The Mexican residents came under the Mexican Farm Labor Program Agreement, also known as the Bracero Program. This was an agreement between Mexicans and the United States governments in August of 1942 to have legal entry and temporary employment for male Mexicans. This started because of the shortage of labor during World War II. After this program ended in 1964, Mexican immigrants stayed and made a Mexican community in Alviso with businesses and churches (Jose, 2024).

Floodplains

Alviso is located below sea level surrounded by marshes, slough, rivers, tidal marshes, mudflats, ponds, salt evaporation, and grasslands. The slough and river in Alviso used to be 150 feet wide and 40 feet deep, which the steamboats used to travel in to get to San Francisco. The farmers created artesian wells to use for irrigation and later switched to mechanical pumps when

the wells dried up. This draining of the aquifers and the weight of the agricultural related machinery and crops caused the land to subside about six feet between the late 1800s and 1970. They faced problems surrounding lack of freshwater, land subsidence, and increased flooding (Masters degree candidates of the Urban & Regional Planning Department, 2009). While some parts of Alviso have subsided almost 13 feet (Jose, 2024). Alviso is also about 13 feet below sea level so it is prone to flooding. This is because of the overuse of aquifers under Alviso which slowly sank the city (Ricci, 2025). The town has flooded 10 significant times and many more times but on a more minor scale. These 10 significant floods were from the Guadalupe River “in 1862, 1895, 1911, 1955, 1958, 1963, 1969, 1982, 1986, 1995” (research4fbf63128f, 2021). This was a result of many factors like the hydraulic mining in Sierra foothills along with the cannery and agricultural workers using the Valley’s aquifer for water. These factors lowered the area’s elevation as well as the levees and dams of the time were not strong enough to prevent the floods (*Alviso Port and Steamboat Tragedy - FoundSF*, 2020). The small scale floods helped to irrigate the crops while the large scale floods caused crops and adobe houses to be washed away. In areas where the land was flat, the water would stay stagnant to create bogs for months and slowly dry out every year. The Guadalupe River was not the only body of water causing these floods. Coyote Creek was working alongside it to cause flooding in Alviso (Masters degree candidates of the Urban & Regional Planning Department, 2009).

Environment and Animals

There are also many species that live in Alviso, even now, that are endangered or threatened. They are: Burrowing owl, California Ridgway’s Rail, California Black Rail, Western Snowy Plover, California Tiger Salamander, Vernal Pool Tadpole Shrimp, Salt Marsh Harvest Mouse, Central California Coast Steelhead Distinct Population Segment, Longfin Smelt, and

Contra Costa Goldfields (RailPros, 2020). Along with these local species, there are invasive plant species that block off the local waterways. The South Bay Salt Pond Restoration Project found that they could not slowly restore the habitat because the animals became dependent on it. They had to work even slower by doing small test projects that could be reversible so that they could be done carefully before the large projects took place. They have a goal to restore the salt ponds to tidal prism by 2057. These projects by the South Bay Salt Pond Restoration Project can help to unclog the waterways and restore habitats for the endangered as well as threatened species in Alviso (Masters degree candidates of the Urban & Regional Planning Department, 2009).

Alviso has a wildlife refuge called the Don Edwards San Francisco Bay National Wildlife Refuge. It also has the Environmental Education Center in it to teach people about the species in Alviso. The Wildlife Refuge has trails people can follow where they can hear around 260 different species of birds (Masters degree candidates of the Urban & Regional Planning Department, 2009).

Engineering

There were many projects that happened in Alviso because of the cannery, storage, manufacturing, steamboat, and flood prevention. As stated by the Masters degree candidates of the Urban & Regional Planning Department in 2009, there are different projects that were planned out like the South Bay Salt Pond Restoration Project. Another project stated by RailPros was to work on the Alviso Wetland Railroad Adaptation Alternatives Study. This was to use the old railroad tracks by adjusting the path and making it so that there were two railroads instead of one. This way trains can go back and front without having to worry about a train coming in the other direction (RailPros, 2020). The US Army Corps of Engineers is responsible for repairs of

the dikes, dams, and levees. There are engineering opportunities to build new housing and walkways on stilts so that they can better survive the flood environment and bring attraction along with curiosity to visitors.

Affect Change in Alviso

Difficulties

Alviso has such little funding and resources that even now the residents need to go to the single post office in town to get their mail (research4fbf63128f, 2021). However, the early residents in Alviso were able to get schools, stores, residences, and civil buildings even without the New Chicago promises which were never done. The residents built water control and treatment advancements after all of the major floods occurred showing that even in the past Alviso was not taken seriously. The residents also faced long slow periods of economic progress for many years (Jose, 2024). Furthermore, they currently have one healthcare center and one hospital outside of the town. There is a lack of amenities like major grocery stores, gas stations, and healthy food sources (Masters degree candidates of the Urban & Regional Planning Department, 2009). Alviso gained access to daily resources in 1968 because of the residents voting to become a part of San Jose. This allowed Alviso to gain “fire and police protection, drinking water, a library, community center, pool, park, storm drains, and street paving” (research4fbf63128f, 2021). However, in return, the city “gained access to the shoreline, garbage dumps, and the ability to expand the sewage treatment plant” (research4fbf63128f, 2021). Alviso has had a difficult time gaining progress, funding, or resources because of the years of neglect that it has faced from the city along with the environmental challenges it faces. The city has and will unfortunately prioritize the profitable businesses, residents, and land over the area that is prone to flooding.

Progress

On the positive side, there have also been efforts in growing Alviso after being included as a part of San Jose. The southern San Francisco Bay has six agencies working to protect the habitats, flood prevention efforts, and recreation. These agencies are: the Fish and Wildlife Service, the California Department of Fish and Game, the US Army Corps of Engineers, the Santa Clara Valley Water District, the Alameda County Water District, and the California Coastal Commission. These agencies work to restore the tidal prism as part of the South Bay Salt Pond Restoration Project. This is the largest wetland restoration project on the West Coast (Masters degree candidates of the Urban & Regional Planning Department, 2009). All of the positive changes that have occurred are towards environmental restoration while the town community still faced little to no changes other than basic amenities.

What Needs to be Done

Something that I wish was available so people can help is some type of program to help donate or nonprofit to help fund Alviso. Since there are none, there are a few different outcomes I hope can occur from this project. I intend to interview the residents on if they have seen change or if they are happy in the condition they are left in. Something else I think would be interesting is asking local trail walkers and residents in other parts of the Bay Area if they know about the town in Alviso. This can help understand whether the town is still unknown to locals or if this information is outdated. The final plan is to gather all the current research and the compared research from the Masters degree candidates of the Urban & Regional Planning Department, 2009 Assessment Report to give in to the City of San Jose office, via email or print it and hand it in person, so they can provide the needed help for Alviso. By doing this, the City of San Jose would have enough information or data and not have the excuse of lack of information.

Something that can make a larger impact and put pressure on the City of San Jose is to detail the benefits of Alviso has and can have on profiting the City of San Jose. Furthermore, adding a petition of sorts to show people care about Alviso and that these changes must happen would put added pressure on the City of San Jose.

Conclusion

Alviso now has the ruins of the historic site and is largely seen by local outdoor enthusiasts walking on the Alviso Marina County Park. The Bay Area needs to work towards preserving yet providing more modern resources to the residents of Alviso to make things more accessible and safe. The main efforts should be put into flood prevention because there are such large technology companies near Alviso, yet they have not done much to help in any way. There needs to be more care from the city to provide support for the residents who are living in Alviso. The city needs to do more towards underdeveloped areas, like Alviso, rather than continuing to overfund some of the other cities that have more than enough to survive for a while. There should be more involvement and contribution to help Alviso grow alongside the other residential areas nearby and keep the environment habitable for the species there. For this to happen there needs to be a greater effort towards the flood prevention plans, restoration of historic landmarks, and adding modern amenities to the communities. The city should also use the natural environment and beauty of Alviso to attract people outside of the community by building unique features that correlate to the history of Alviso. By doing so the community will be happy and healthy as well as included in the rest of the Bay Area instead of being isolated.

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